

A FUNCTIONAL ANALYSIS OF AMERICAN MAYORAL DEBATES

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Introduction

Political campaign debates have a long history in the United States. Perhaps the best known political debates from America's past are the Lincoln-Douglas debates. Although these two politicians would subsequently contest for the presidency, their famous debates occurred in the campaign to be the U.S. Senator from Illinois. The earliest presidential debate on record is a radio debate in 1948 between Dewey and Stassen in the Oregon primary campaign (Kane, 1987). The earliest televised non-presidential debate featured Lucia Cormier and Margaret Chase Smith in a 1960 contest for a U.S. Senate seat (Sarkela, 2005). In recent years, presidential primary debates have proliferated, with 22 debates in 2000 (9 Democratic and 13 Republican; Benoit et al., 2003), 21 Democratic debates in 2004 (Benoit et al., 2007). As of April of 2008, 47 presidential primary debates had been held, with 3 presidential and 1 vice presidential debate scheduled. However, debates for other political offices have also become a staple of campaigns in recent years.

Debates by definition address propositions, so it can be argued that political campaign debates resemble press conferences more than traditional debates (Auer, 1962; Jamieson & Birdsell, 1988; Zarefsky, 1992). Nevertheless, there can be no doubt that these messages are important for several reasons. First, campaign debates usually include leading candidates addressing the same topics simultaneously on the same stage, helping potential voters learn about the candidates before they make their vote choice. Furthermore, political campaign debates are as long as 90 minutes,

offering viewers an opportunity to compare the candidates and their position in some depth, particularly in contrast to TV spots (which are usually 30 seconds long) and news stories. Third, candidates typically prepare for their debates; still, that they are relatively unscripted requires that candidates be spontaneous. They may face unexpected questions or be the target of unanticipated attacks from opponents. Accordingly, debates provide a relatively more candid view of the candidates than other message forms. Fourth, the face-to-face confrontation which occurs in political debates gives candidates a chance to challenge the accidental or intentional misstatements, of their opponents. This clash has the potential to provide citizens greater insights into the issues at play in an election.

Yet another reason to study political debates is the potential for influence. Louden (2005) observed that “the occurrence of presidential to non-presidential debates is overwhelmingly in favor of state and local debates. Virtually every U.S. senate contest and governor’s race, in addition to many congressional elections, will feature political debates” (p. 41). Furthermore, Ornstein (1987) noted “the impact of debates is heightened because they are frequently televised on both commercial and public channels. . . . Nearly 50% of the stations actually aired political debates” (p. 58). The Racine Group (2002) observed that “while journalists and scholars display varying degrees of cynicism about the debates, few deny that viewers find them useful and almost no one doubts that they play an important role in national campaigns” (p. 201), concluding that “There is strong empirical support for the contribution of televised debates to viewer learning” (p. 207) and that “debates do influence viewer perceptions and, as a consequence, influence voting disposition” (p. 209). Meta-analysis reveals that presidential debates have important effects on voters, creating issue knowledge, influencing perceptions of the candidates’ character, and at times altering vote choice (Benoit, Hansen, & Verser, 2003). These encounters provide an opportunity for interested voters to learn about the candidates (both directly and via press reports); they also provide a

chance for candidates to present and clarify their platforms—as well as to alter the direction of their campaign if needed.

Research on the effects of non-presidential campaign debates is much less common than studies of presidential debate effects. Still, some studies indicate that these encounters also have the potential to influence viewers. Philport and Balon (1975) looked at the 1974 Democratic Ohio Senate primary contest between John Glenn and Howard Metzenbaum, reporting that Glenn's image had been influenced by the debate. Lichtenstein (1982) found that "local debates were perceived as considerably more informative and influential to the viewers than the presidential debates" (p. 294). Just, Crigler, and Wallach (1990) argued that those who watched a Connecticut House debate in 1984 learned about candidate issue positions. Bystrom, Roper, Gobetz, Massey, and Veal (1991) argued that watching a 1990 Oklahoma gubernatorial debate affected perceptions of the candidates' images and issue positions and, particularly for undecided viewers, assisted in the decision-making process. Hullett and Loudon (1998) found that those who watched a 1994 Congressional debate recalled more statements from their preferred candidate. Robertson (2005) found that 2004 Senate debates in South Dakota influenced viewer vote choice, perceptions of the candidates' character, and preferences for candidate policy positions. So, non-presidential debates have the potential to influence viewers. Unquestionably, political debates merit scholarly attention; this paper focuses on debates for the office of mayor.

Most research on campaign debates has focused on presidential debates, as Loudon noted, despite the fact that there are many more non-presidential than presidential debates, published research is tilted in the opposite direction, "with presidential encounters capturing nearly all the attention" (p. 41). In fact, McKinney and Carlin (2004) lament the "lack of research on non-presidential debates," particularly given how frequently they occur (p. 226). Pfau (1983) investigated format in non-presidential debates. Ornstein (1987) presents a conceptual discussion of non-presidential debates instead of research on

debate content or effects. Conrad concluded a rhetorical analysis of narrative form in the 1984 Helms-Hunt Senate debate (1993). Airne and Benoit (2005) examined the 2004 Senate debates between Obama and Keyes: 59% of the statements were acclaims, 37% were attacks, and 4% were defenses; policy was discussed more often than character (65% to 35%). Banwart and McKinney (2005) studied two U.S. senate and two gubernatorial debates from 2000 and 2002, reporting that positive comments (79%) and policy discussion (82%) dominated these encounters. These studies are a useful beginning, but the sample of debates, candidates, and years is still very small.

This study presents a content analysis of mayoral debates. Some research (e.g., Banwart & McKinney, 2005; Johnson, 1996) suggests that certain features of debates could vary by political office, one reason to extend current research on political debates to the office of mayor. This study adopts the Functional approach to studying campaign messages (Benoit, 2007). This is only one possible approach to studying these debates; however, applying this theory allows us to extend existing research to a new context, mayoral debates. Furthermore, we argue that replication is vital to the research process in order to provide more confidence in our conclusions (Rosenthal, 1991). As Lamal (1991) explained, replication is “necessary because our knowledge is corrigible” (p. 31). Thus, we extend current research applying Functional Theory (Benoit, 2007) to mayoral debates.

Theoretical Approach

Benoit’s (2007) Functional Theory of Political Campaign Discourse will provide the theoretical framework used in this study. Political campaign messages have three functions: acclaims, which praise the candidate; attacks, which attack the opponent; and defenses, which refute attacks. Of course, third party candidates and some candidates in primary campaigns may run merely to champion a cause; Functional Theory focuses on candidates who are genuinely seeking elective office. Such candidates need to convince voters that they are preferable to opponents and preferability can only be established by indicating that one is

desirable (acclaims), that an opponent is undesirable (attacks), or that alleged weaknesses are false (defenses).

Campaign messages can concern two pertinent topics: policy (governmental action and problems amenable to governmental action) and character (the qualities and abilities of the candidates). Examples of policy topics include employment, health care, crime, and education. Each of these topics is divided further. Policy utterances can focus on past deeds (governmental action), future plans (specific proposals for governmental action), and general goals (ends sought by the candidates). Character statements can concern personal qualities (personality), leadership ability (governmental experience), or ideals (values and principles). For example, character utterances include questions about whether a candidate can be trusted or has the experience needed to govern successfully. The Appendix offers an example of an attack and an acclaim on each of these forms of policy and character taken from a mayoral debate.

In his Functional Theory, Benoit (2007) argues that acclaims have no drawbacks whereas attacks have one drawback and defenses have three. Voters report that they dislike mudslinging (Merritt, 1984; Stewart, 1975), so there could be backlash against candidates who attack. Because one must identify the attack to refute it, defenses can (1) remind or inform viewers of a potential weakness of the defender, (2) create the impression that the defending candidate was reactive rather than proactive, (3) take a candidate off-message, discussing his or her weaknesses rather than strengths. For these reasons, the functions should be ordered generally in this way (it is possible that some individual candidates will choose not to conform to these expectations):

H1. Acclaims will be the most frequently expressed function, and defenses the least frequent, in mayoral debates.

Incumbents have numerous advantages over challengers (such as greater name recognition, fund-raising ability, experience; see Trent & Friedenberg, 2000; Trent & Trent, 1995). Accordingly, challengers usually need to provide voters a reason to

oust the incumbent and the way to reduce a candidate's apparent desirability is through attacks.

H2. Incumbents will acclaim more, and attack less, than challengers (or open seat candidates) in mayoral debates.

It is important that only incumbents have a record in the office sought; challengers may have experience in other offices, but challengers rarely have experience as mayor. An incumbent's record can be expected to contain both successes and failures, so the incumbent's record is a resource for incumbents to acclaim and for challengers to attack (of course, incumbents sometimes attack the challenger's record and sometimes challengers acclaim their own record—but these two kinds of remarks occur less frequently than discussions of the incumbent's record by incumbent and challenger alike).

H3. Incumbents will use past deeds more to acclaim—and less to attack—than challengers in mayoral debates.

Voters at both the presidential (Benoit, 2003) and congressional level (Brazeal & Benoit, 2001) report that policy is a more important determinant of their vote than is character. Although it is possible that this preference may not be occur in mayoral debates, it is reasonable to assume that:

H4. Policy will be discussed more than character in mayoral debates.

Research using Functional Theory (e.g., Benoit, 2007) found that acclaims are more common than attacks in both general goals and ideals. It is much easier to agree with (acclaim) than to disagree with (attack) many goals and ideals, such as creating more jobs or the importance of equality.

H5. General goals will be used more to acclaim than attack in mayoral debates.

H6. Ideals will be used more to acclaim than attack in mayoral debates.

Testing these hypotheses with mayoral debates will add to our understanding of political debates.

Method

Statements by the candidates in these debates were unitized into themes, which are claims, statements, or arguments (a sentence may contain one or more themes; a theme could also span more than one sentence). Berelson (1952) indicated that a theme is “an assertion about a subject” (p. 18). Holsti (1969) defines a theme as “a single assertion about some subject” (p. 116). For example, in the New York City mayoral debate, Michael Bloomberg suggested that we should “continue to make sure that every child gets a good education. If we continue the course of making sure that this city is safe, safe from criminals and safe from terrorism” (11/1/05). This remark illustrates three themes: education, crime, and terrorism.

Each theme was then classified by function (acclaim, attack, or defense), topic (policy or character), and then form of policy (past deed, future plan, or general goal) or of character (personal quality, leadership ability, or ideal). We also noted the incumbency status (incumbent, challenger, open seat) of these candidates. Because this method generates frequency data, chi-squares were employed to test the hypotheses.

Three coders, who were trained in the coding system, content analyzed these texts. Intercoder reliability for these debates, calculated on 10% of the texts, was measured with Cohen’s (1960) *kappa*. The values of *kappa* were .94 for functions, .91 for topics, .87 for forms of policy, and .85 for forms of character. Landis and Koch (1977) explain that *kappas* of .81 or higher reflect almost perfect agreement between coders, so these values represent acceptable reliability.

Sample

There is no complete collection of non-presidential debates from which one can randomly select debates for analysis. So, of necessity, we employed a convenience sample of debates with transcripts located on the Internet. This sample consisted of ten mayoral debates held between 2005 and 2007, two from primary campaigns and eight from general election campaigns. Cities varied in population from about 19,000 to over 8 million (Brookfield, WI; Frederick, MI; Laurel, MS; New Orleans, LA;

New York City, NY; Pittsburgh, PA; San Francisco, CA; Waukesha, WI). The sample included 28 candidates (candidates who participated in both primary and general debates were only counted once) and all but six were affiliated with the Democratic or Republican parties.

Results

The first hypothesis concerned the relative proportions of the three functions of political campaigns in mayoral debate discourse. As predicted, acclaims were most common (75%), followed by attacks (18%) and defenses (7%). For example, in the Pittsburgh mayoral debate, Luke Ravenstahl declared that “The city of Pittsburgh and the Housing Authority recently merged their police departments. [It] saved our city taxpayers money [and] provided more efficient service” (10/11/07). Given that saving money and increasing efficiency are likely to be viewed as desirable, this statement functions as an acclaim. In the same debate, Mark DeSantis charged that “Right now, the city is a fiscal basket case. We have more debt per capita than any city in the country.” Debt is probably seen as undesirable, so this statement illustrates an attack. Ravenstahl responded to this accusation by stating that “I just want to clarify that this city will not go bankrupt in the next two or three years,” illustrating a defense. A chi-square goodness of fit test confirms that this distribution is significantly different from chance ($\chi^2 [df=2]=1356.52, p < .0001$). These data can be found in Table 1.

Table 1: *Functions of Mayoral Debates*

	Acclaims	Attacks	Defenses
Incumbents	318 (76%)	28 (7%)	74 (18%)
Challengers	334 (71%)	123 (26%)	13 (3%)
Open Seat	352 (89%)	30 (8%)	12 (3%)
Total Mayoral	1285 (75%)	326 (19%)	113 (7%)

Note: row percentages may not total 100% due to rounding.

Hypothesis two expected that incumbent candidates would acclaim more, and attacks less, than challengers. This was confirmed with these data: Incumbents acclaimed more (76% to 71%) and attacked less (7% to 26%) than challengers (the table includes data from open seat candidates even though no prediction is made for that group). A chi-square test of cross classification revealed that these differences were statistically significant ($\chi^2 [df=1] = 45.69, p < .0001, \phi = .24$). These data are also reported in Table 1.

Next, we probed for potential differences in function between incumbents and challengers. H3 focuses on past deeds (accomplishments or failures in office). The prediction that incumbents will employ past deeds to acclaim more, and attack less, than challengers, was confirmed. 94% of the incumbents' past deeds were acclaims whereas 6% were attacks; in contrast, 28% of challengers' past deeds were acclaims and 72% were attacks. Challenger Mark DeSantis's attack on the incumbent's fiscal record is an example of an attack on past deeds; incumbent Rafenstahl's statement about merger of the city and Housing Authority police departments illustrates an acclaim on past deeds. A chi-square test of cross classification confirmed that these differences were significant ($\chi^2 [df=1] = 94.74, p < .0001, \phi = .69$). These data are displayed in Table 2.

Table 2.

Forms of Policy and Character in Mayoral Debates

	Policy					Character						
	Past Deeds		Future Plans		General Goals	Personal Qualities		Leadership Ability		Ideals		
Incumbents	106	7	13	4	137	4	31	12	21	1	10	0
Challengers	24	63	48	9	147	10	67	27	25	13	23	1
Open Seat	51	18	20	0	160	3	42	4	47	4	32	1
Total	210	164	113	14	611	20	161	83	120	39	70	6

H4 anticipated that the comments in these debates would focus more on policy than character. This was indeed the case: Policy accounted for 70% of the themes in these debates, whereas character was 30%. In the Pittsburgh debate (10/11/07), DeSantis said that “my micro-loan program will provide loans from \$500 to \$5,000 to small businesses and the people who will choose the loan won't be a banker, it will be the peers of that individual trying to seek that loan. And they won't need collateral, they won't a credit check. This program has worked in Philadelphia; it has worked in other cities as well. It has worked in cities around the world, and it can work here.” A proposal to loan money to small businesses is a clearly example of a policy utterance. In contrast, Ravenstahl declared that “The residents of the city of Pittsburgh need a mayor that's a leader. They need a mayor that is willing to make the tough decisions.” This statement illustrates a character utterance. These differences were significant ($\chi^2 [df=1] = 263.88, p < .0001$). See Table 3 for these data.

Table 3.
Topics of Mayoral Debates

	Policy	Character
Incumbents	372 (83%)	75 (17%)
Challengers	301 (66%)	156 (34%)
Open Seat	252 (66%)	130 (34%)
Total Mayoral	1132 (70%)	479 (30%)

The fifth hypothesis concerned the functions of general goals. As anticipated, this form of policy was employed more often to acclaim than attack (97% to 3%). A chi-square goodness of fit test indicates that the functions of general goals occur at significantly different frequencies ($\chi^2 [df=1] = 5.22, p < .05$). The final hypothesis addressed the functions of ideals. Again, this form of character was used more frequently as the basis of acclaims than attacks (92% to 8%). A goodness of fit test shows that these

differences are significant ($\chi^2 [df = 1] = 52.22, p < .0001$). These data can be found in Table 2.

Discussion

Mayoral debates, as a whole, use acclaims more often than attacks and defenses least often (acclaims 75%, attacks 19%, defenses 7%). As explained previously, acclaims have no drawbacks, attacks have one (voters' aversion to mudslinging), and defenses have three disadvantages (a defense could inform or remind the audience of a weakness, they may create the impression that the candidate is reactive rather than proactive, and they may take a candidate off-message). This distribution of functions conforms generally to the pattern found in presidential general election debates: 57% acclaims, 35% attacks, and 8% defenses (Benoit, 2007).

Candidates who are seeking re-election were prone to acclaim more, and attack less, than challengers. This may be due in part to the fact that challengers often need to give voters a reason to reject the incumbent. This pattern was consistent with that found in presidential general election debates: Incumbents acclaimed more (64% to 51%) and attacked less (25% to 44%) than challengers (Benoit, 2007). One unusual element of these data is that mayoral incumbents defended more than they attacked; however, incumbents were subjected to many more attacks than challengers, which provide greater motivation and more opportunity for incumbents to defend than challengers. Another reason for the disparity in use of functions by incumbents and challengers can be found in the candidates' use of past deeds. Although challengers may have experience in another office, no experience elsewhere is as relevant to the election as experience in the office sought. Accordingly, both incumbents and challengers have a tendency to discuss the incumbent's record. Obviously, incumbents will acclaim when talking about their record whereas challengers will attack when discussing the incumbent's record. This was the case in mayoral debates; it was also the pattern in presidential debates. Incumbents acclaimed more (72% to 18%) and attacked less (28% to 82%) than challengers when discussing

past deeds (Benoit, 2007). The effect size here was quite large: $\phi = .69$.

Candidates in mayoral debates focused more on policy than character. Although we have no data on voter preferences in mayoral elections specifically, polls on presidential (Benoit, 2003) and congressional (Brazeal & Benoit, 2001) indicate that most voters in those races consider policy more important than character. Presidential debates also stress policy more than character (75% to 25%; Benoit, 2007).

Candidates face an easier task when acclaiming than attacking most goals and ideals. Who could oppose more jobs, less crime, justice, or freedom? The candidates in these mayoral debates were more likely to use general goals and ideals to acclaim than attack (general goals: 97% acclaims, 3% attacks; ideals: 92% acclaims, 8% attacks). This relationship was true of general election debates (general goals: 85% acclaims, 15% attacks; ideals: 82% acclaims, 18% attacks; Benoit, 2007).

Conclusion

Political election campaign debates for offices at all levels of government are becoming more common as time passes. This study contributes to our understanding of certain aspects of these campaign events, analyzing the functions and topics of mayoral debates. The results of this analysis, along with findings from previous research on presidential debates, reveals consistent relationships in campaign debate messages (e.g., functions, incumbency, and topics) across campaign office. Indeed, analysis of political leaders' debates in other countries reveals similar patterns (Benoit & Klyukovski, 2006; Benoit & Sheafer, 2006; Benoit, Wen, & Yu, 2007). These findings suggest that some aspects of political campaign messages, such as functions and topics of messages, remain constant across contexts. To the extent such consistency exists (and we do not claim there are no contextual differences), it makes researching and teaching campaign messages simpler. The nature of the political campaign situation—competing with opponents to win elective office—encourages candidates for political office to adopt similar message

strategies. Clearly other variables and other political campaign messages deserve scholarly attention, but we are building our knowledge of such messages through research. Further research could investigate political debates for other offices, such as governor and senator, as well as more recent debates.

Appendix: Examples of Acclaims and Attacks on the Forms of Policy and Character

Forms of Policy

Past Deeds

Acclaim: We have given our teachers a 33% raise over the last four years (Bloomberg)

Attack: Look, it's a 50% drop out rate. One out of two kids without a diploma, without a future, and without a job. (Ferrer)

Future Plans

Acclaim: In the case of avian flu, [we must] have enough vaccine stockpiled so that we can take care of New Yorkers. (Ferrer)

Attack: Why are there secret memos emerging about the city guaranteeing to . . . give this developer 2,600 units of luxury housing. By the way with tax breaks from the city. (Ferrer)

General Goals

Acclaim: We need to replace office space and commercial space. (Ferrer)

Attack: He wants to build affordable housing and so do I. The difference is I have a way to do it with capital funds; he is going to have to do it with raising taxes. (Bloomberg)

Forms of Character

Personal Qualities

Acclaim: I want my children to look at me and say, "Daddy, you governed honestly. You governed fairly." (Bloomberg)

Attack: I think everyone knows what my opponent stands for: He stands for complaining. (Bloomberg)

Leadership Ability

Acclaim: [The mayor of New York City has] a bully pulpit second in size and mass only to the

president of the United States. That's leadership.
(Ferrer)

Attack: I don't think you can approach this [getting
education money from the state] as a CEO in a
negotiation by putting zero on the table and
waiting for them to come up. (Ferrer)

Ideals

Acclaim: There is only one principle that has ever
guided any decision I have ever made: That is
this - that every New Yorker who works hard
and does right should get the tools they need to
build a better life here in the city. (Ferrer)

Attack: You can't disclaim for the policies while
you are opening your checkbook wide. . .
Mike..., you are a [conservative] Republican.
(Ferrer)

(Excerpts from the November 1, 2005 New York City
mayoral debate)

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